Big Countdown: SWOT & Strategic Matrix

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> **Bottom line.** $29 is a strong way to get people in the door, but it won't keep them. Stagetimer already has Stream Deck control through Companion, an offline desktop app, and a one-time desktop-only lifetime license. Ontime is free, works offline, and has full Companion, OSC and HTTP control. Today you win on price and setup speed. To keep winning, you need a reliability story and control-surface support within about 90 days.

What this rests on: bigcount.online could not be reached from the analysis environment, so the product description comes from the founder's brief. Competitor facts were checked against Stagetimer's and Ontime's own docs. Stagetimer's pricing page lists Pro at about $210/yr and Premium at about $420/yr (billed annually); confirm before quoting publicly.

S 1. Strengths (internal)

Strength	Why it matters to an AV operator	How defensible
$29 lifetime price	A freelance A1/A2 can pay for it out of one day rate with no PO needed. A small church can buy it without a budget line. Stagetimer Pro costs about 7× that every year.	**Low.** Price is easy to copy, and Stagetimer already sells a one-time desktop license.
Free up to 3 min, plus `/try` with no signup	A tech can test it on the actual confidence monitor at load-in, before committing. That's the moment buying decisions happen.	Medium. You can test everything but can't run a real show.
Browser only, instant QR pairing	Works on a venue PC, rental laptop or client machine where you can't install software. The phone remote can be handed to a stage manager in seconds.	Medium. Ontime needs local setup; Stagetimer is also browser-based.
Two clear modes (HDMI vs. wireless remote)	Matches the two real setups: one operator at FOH with a laptop, or an operator walking the room with the stage display wired to the monitor.	Medium
AV-specific features	Silent flash messages, red overtime count-up, rundown with CSV import (fits how producers already build run-of-show in Sheets/Excel), OBS/vMix chroma and transparent output for hybrid streams.	**Low.** Every serious competitor has these. They let you compete, not win.
Edge hosting	Low latency for remotes in different regions.	Low

Candid take: Of these, only price, pairing speed and the trial limit actually set you apart. The feature list mostly gets you into the conversation.

W 2. Weaknesses (internal)

1. **No offline guarantee. This is the biggest gap.** A stage timer that dies when venue Wi-Fi drops is a career risk for whoever chose it. Experienced techs will reject it on that alone. Stagetimer offers an offline desktop app and Ontime is local-first; Big Countdown offers neither.
2. **No hardware or control-protocol support.** Companion/Stream Deck, OSC, HTTP API, MIDI and tally are how professional shows are run. Without them you're shut out of the corporate and broadcast operators who influence what everyone else uses.

3. **Lifetime revenue doesn't match ongoing costs.** Every buyer brings permanent costs (realtime connections, support, Paddle fees of about 5% + $0.50) with no further revenue. Heavy users, like a rental house running 20 displays every weekend, cost the most.
4. **No multi-room or multi-operator setup.** Conferences with breakouts need one producer watching every room. Single-session tools stay "a freelancer's tool."
5. **Trust and brand.** A new `.online` domain, no reviews, no named customers and no uptime history all count against you with corporate producers, where "is this vendor still around next year?" is a real procurement question.
6. **Paddle checkout.** Fine for individuals, but agencies want invoices, VAT handling and team seats. Paddle does handle invoicing; make sure that's visible on the site.

O 3. Opportunities (external)

Segments (best first)

- **Church tech teams:** huge numbers, mostly volunteers, price-sensitive, same weekly service. Rundown templates plus a phone remote suit them well, and churches recommend tools to each other.
- **AV rental and staging companies:** one license per tech kit. "Include it in every rental package." A white-label or operator-kit bundle fits.
- **Hackathons, pitch competitions, TEDx, school and university events:** small budgets, organizers rotate yearly, so repeated new buyers. The free 3-minute tier fits some pitch formats.
- **Hybrid webinar and streaming producers:** OBS/vMix output works with no extra setup.
- **Toastmasters and debate clubs:** large, organized, short-format. Possibly a dedicated free or cheap tier.

Channels

- Reddit: r/livesound, r/CommercialAV, r/VIDEOENGINEERING, r/churchtech, r/obs. Post as a tech answering questions, not as an advertiser.
- Bitfocus Companion module directory: in front of exactly the right operators.
- Elgato Stream Deck marketplace plugin (churches, streamers).
- Church tech communities, Facebook groups, ChurchFront and Church Media Drop audiences.
- Comparison searches: "Stagetimer alternative," "stage timer no subscription," "free confidence monitor timer."
- AlternativeTo, Capterra, G2, Product Hunt (mainly for backlinks and trust).

Features that spread through venues

- **Multi-room dashboard:** one producer sees every breakout room. Each room's display shows "Powered by Big Countdown," and the venue's house AV team notices.
- **Calendar and Sheets sync:** a live Google Sheet becomes the run-of-show; producer changes appear right away.
- **Shareable viewer link** for green room, backstage and the client, so more people see the product.

T 4. Threats (external)

1. **Stagetimer lowers the price or pushes its lifetime desktop license.** They already have one and could promote it against you tomorrow. They also have SEO, docs and integrations you don't.
2. **Ontime is free, solid and keeps improving.** Technical operators happy to self-host won't pay $29 for less.

3. **Venue networks.** Guest Wi-Fi with client isolation, captive portals that time out mid-show, corporate firewalls blocking WebSockets, RF-crowded ballrooms. Any of these makes the phone remote unreliable. The failure happens live, and that's what people remember and tell each other.
4. **Copies.** "Build a stage timer" is a weekend project with AI tools; expect cheap or free copies to flood search results.
5. **Platform features.** vMix, ProPresenter (big in churches), Resolume and presentation tools ship their own countdown and stage-display features. "Good enough and already installed" beats "better but separate."
6. **Hardware buyers** (D'San Limitimer and similar) see web tools as toys, which caps credibility in high-end corporate work.

5. Strategic Matrix

S+O Win over subscription users

1. **"Switch from Stagetimer" page (month 1):** honest comparison table, cost calculator ("$X over 3 years vs. $29"), and import for Stagetimer/Ontime rundown CSVs.
2. **"First gig free" for techs (months 1–2):** unlock one full-length show by email signup. Turns the 3-minute limit into a real load-in test and collects leads.
3. **Rental house kit (months 2–4):** 10 licenses for about $199 with a co-branded operator quick-start PDF. Sell directly to 30–50 regional staging companies.
4. **Church templates (month 2):** pre-built Sunday rundowns (worship, announcements, sermon, response), distributed through church tech groups, landing page at `/church`.

W+O Fix the offline and trust gaps

1. **Work without internet (months 1–3). Top priority.**
   - Short term: PWA with service worker so HDMI mode runs fully offline. Say it plainly: "HDMI mode works with Wi-Fi off."
   - Medium term: local-network fallback, either a small Tauri/Electron app serving the remote over LAN, or WebRTC peer-to-peer with the edge server used only to pair.
   - Document a $30 travel-router setup for restrictive venues. Techs trust tools that admit where they fail.
2. **Companion module + HTTP/OSC API (months 2–3):** start, stop, add time, next segment, send message, with button feedback for time remaining and overtime. Biggest single credibility step with pro operators.
3. **Trust (all six months):** public status page, 5–10 named case studies with show photos, a named founder, a written "lifetime" promise (what's covered, what happens if the company shuts down). Consider a `.com`/`.app` for paid campaigns.

S+T Defend against copies and incumbents

1. **Compete on speed and zero setup, not feature count.** "Show-ready in 60 seconds, no account for the stage screen, no install" is something Ontime can't promise. Record a side-by-side setup video.
2. **Keep $29 lifetime for one operator; add a Venue / Multi-room tier (months 4–6)** at about $149 lifetime or $10/mo: multi-room dashboard, more concurrent displays, team seats. Protects margin without breaking the no-subscription promise.
3. **Ship faster than they can.** Public roadmap and changelog, requests taken in r/livesound threads, shipped within a week.
4. **Own long-tail search terms:** one page each for TEDx timer, Toastmasters timer, church countdown, hackathon pitch timer, OBS countdown overlay, vMix countdown.

W+T Limit the damage

1. **Make failures safe, before anything else.** If the connection drops, the stage display keeps counting locally from the last known state. Show "remote disconnected" to the operator only, never on the speaker's screen; reconnect and resync automatically. Test by killing Wi-Fi mid-countdown.
2. **Cap what lifetime costs you:** fair-use limit on concurrent displays and rooms per license; self-help docs before email support. Model worst-case cost per user per year now.
3. **Put network requirements before checkout:** list ports and domains so venue IT can pre-approve; add a "Network check" button that tests WebSocket reachability before the show.
4. **Protect the brand:** trademark "Big Countdown" if possible; register obvious lookalike domains.

6. 90-Day Order of Work (extending to 6 months)

Weeks	Ship	Measure
1–3	Safe failure + offline HDMI mode (PWA), network-check button, Stagetimer comparison page	Trial → paid %; "offline" search impressions
4–8	Public HTTP/OSC API + Companion module; church and TEDx/Toastmasters landing pages	Companion installs; segment traffic
9–12	Local-network or P2P remote; rental house kit outreach (50 companies)	Kit sales; refund rate
13–24	Multi-room dashboard as paid add-on; Stream Deck plugin; case studies	Average revenue per customer; share of revenue from add-ons

> **If you only do one thing:** guarantee the stage display never goes blank or freezes because of the network, and say so on the homepage. Experienced AV techs pick tools by how they fail, not by price.

Sources

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